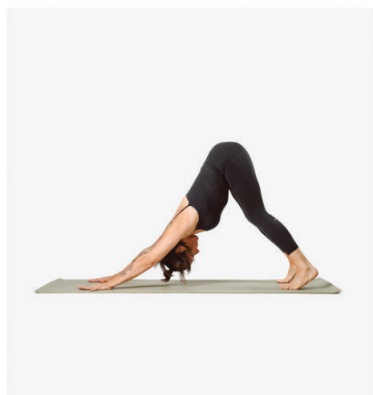


THE SONG IN OUR BONES

EMBODIMENT AND THE MIND-BODY PRACTICES
OF KATONAH YOGA®

KATHERINE COOLEY, PHD



THE SONG IN OUR BONES

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KATONAH YOGA®

Katherine Cooley, PhD

Founder of the Joy Yoga Project

Forward by
Dages Juvelier Keates

Yoga photography by
Brian McDonnell

joyyogaproject.com 214 E 13th Ave. Spokane, WA 99202

DEDICATION

To Nevine Michaan, Abbie Galvin, and Dages Juvelier Keates—a trinity
of luminous teachers whose work embodies the practical, the subtle,
and the mystical realms of being in a body.

With your generosity, poetry, and inspired precision, I have learned to
inhabit the architecture of my own body, to measure breath as light,
and to orient from the divine design in everyday life.

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THE IN-BETWEEN OF EVERYTHING

A FORWARD

When beings are born, we name them. We go around with this set of letters and sounds announcing what kind of creature we are born to be—the language, the culture, the historical moment. Our names tell more about our parents than they do about us.

But one doesn't call oneself by one's own name.

Naming is a practice of thingification. In releasing the names of things, there is an opening to explore the verb-ing, or practice, over the thing-ing of it. An organism exceeds an identity: a person, a plant, a piranha, is a miracle of the universe—what combination of letters can encompass that?

Body contains mind contains brain contains consciousness. Who can tell where one stops or starts? Current research into the microbiome tells us that only 43% of the body's total cell count is human, rendering 57% of "us" microscopic others. The bacteria, fungi, and viruses that constitute the majority of our ecologies are not other. They are us.

This ineffable symphony is a song in our bones, and it can be attuned to through practice. This book is an invitation to that attunement—to expand the capacity for direct experience before giving it a name.

What you will find here is not a manual for self-improvement. The body is not a project to be optimized, purified, or mastered. It is a house to be fully inhabited—a flesh chariot, a magical abode, a mobile home—a spatiotemporal address in which to deform, reform, transform, and become formidable. A place to drop off identity, to attune, and to sing.

It's a surprise. Improvise.

— Dages Juvelier Keates

INTRODUCTION: THE SONG IN OUR BONES

The body disappears as the center of experience at the very moment that it functions best. Drew Leder

I have heard the experience of losing a loved one described as the sudden *presence of their absence*.¹ That phrase really resonated with me. Where their body, mind, and breath once were, in one's lived space, there is now a palpable, visceral, and felt sense of emptiness. And over time, it is this presence of their absence that slowly fades.

In his book, *The Absent Body*,² philosopher and physician Drew Leder draws on a similar phenomenon to describe how we become estranged from our own bodies. Just as we acclimate to the absence of someone we've lost, Leder argues that in everyday life, we often acclimate to the absence of the body itself. The body, including the mind and breath, while foundational to all experience, frequently recedes from awareness, especially when it functions smoothly. It becomes absent even as it structures our world.

While this absence can be understood as beneficial,³ freeing us to experience ourselves at the center of a sphere of concentrated radiance, able to focus on the world and function well, it comes with a risk. When the body is absent from our awareness for too long, we may not give it the care and attention it needs. As Leder suggests, the body tends to ap

pear only in moments of breakdown, the breath gets thin, and the mind becomes fixated on the same few thoughts.

Without techniques that restore function as well as awareness of what we need and when, we risk knowing the body only through its pain, dysfunction, or decline. Over time, this absence becomes more than a coping mechanism; it becomes an embodied pattern of disconnection.⁴ One in which sensation is muted, presence is replaced by performance, and the body becomes something we manage rather than inhabit. The body becomes flat, and with that so does the mind, and the breath.

This phenomenon is not just individual; it is also cultural. We live in a world that rewards the appearance of doing, often at the expense of sensation and slowness, or of being. In such a system, the body becomes either a tool to optimize or a problem to fix. We are trained to dismiss its whispers until they become too loud to ignore. We pathologize, simplify, and diagnose. Culture flattens the body. And when embodiment is not modeled, not understood, and not practiced, our kinesthetic traditions become more dilute, and we slowly forget how to inhabit ourselves. We become spectators in our own bodies.⁵

But what if presence is not only something we regain in crisis? What if it can be cultivated before it breaks down? Somatic practices, contemplative movement, and even the simplest acts of reinhabiting our bodies, like feeling our feet on the floor or tracking our breath, can begin to reawaken the body's role as a source of implicit direction. These practices help restore a more continuous, subtle kind of presence, and this one is not dependent on dysfunction to make itself known. These approaches are not about achieving some ideal state but about remembering the body's thesis: that it is a living process, and to attend to it is to re-enter a relationship that grounds us in our whole selves, in time, space, and

being. They teach us how to have a body, how not to lose our minds, and how to feed our spirits.

To heed the body's thesis is to begin singing its song again, not as background noise, but as the primary melody of our lived experience. We each have a song in our bones. A song has a current, meter, it has a tone, and all songs have breath. Our song invites expression, generates insight, and connects us to each other. The world needs our songs, not the song we've been told to sing, but the one that feels, moves, and radiates. The world needs to hear the song in your bones.



CHAPTER TWO: PRACTICES

Embodiment Practice

Across cultures and eras, people have wrestled with the same dilemma: how to have a mind without losing it. How to be in a body and find joy, avoid bitterness, and feel good.

They have asked: Why does my body feel separate from my mind? Where do my thoughts end and my body begin?

Many have tried to master the mind with thought alone. But I lean toward another view: you cannot take the fortress by charging its front gate. Because the mind resists direct assault, meeting every advance with more thought. We need another way. As I've explored here, that way is through the body, for the body already holds the mind and the spirit. And, in my view, a method that explores the mind, body, and breath is one that examines our embodiment.

I define embodiment as the ongoing process of being that resides in and manifests from one's biology, psychology, and environment, not as observed from the outside but as experienced from within.⁶ As I discuss in Chapters 4 and 5, along with the body we are born with, much of our embodiment is shaped by processes, experiences, and circumstances that we are largely unconscious of. An embodiment practice, therefore, is the intentional reforming, partial recuperating,⁷ and perhaps even re



awakening of parts that over time have gone offline, out of balance, or developed as a compensatory pattern no longer needed. In other words, it is bringing that which is unconscious, in our minds and our bodies, to light.

The Katonah Yoga® practices are embodiment practices. They center the body as the container for the elixir of our spirit. And it is a work in progress. I always think of the La Sagrada Familia in Barcelona, which has been being built for over one hundred years. The building continues, and the sections that need repair are being repaired simultaneously. It is a perfect example of how we are building and rebuilding our own cathedrals to house our spirit, and that it is an ongoing process without end until our last breath.

Why We Measure

An embodiment practice is about becoming conscious of what was previously unconscious, thereby giving you the capacity to decide how you want to be in the world. What's interesting is that though working in our corporal infrastructure requires effort, it is less personal than you might think. This is because the body is less corrupted and more easily

organized than the mind. A muscle has no will of its own.⁸ Fascia is only shaped through patterns and repetition. Joints will move back into position when given good information. I used to say that my thighs don't think they are too big. Our body does not evaluate itself. Therefore, for something to be so primary to our experiencing life (our body), it is much easier to adjust, amend, and alter than our mind.

Our body also doesn't have attachments and aversions, preferences, and feelings the way our mind does. Even though feelings feel very bodily, our feelings about something or a situation can change very quickly when we get new information. Lao Tzu said that the man who sees only five colors is blind, and the one who hears only five notes is deaf. Meaning our feelings, whether you mean sensations or emotions, are good to have, to explore, and to reflect on. But don't use them without some other way to gauge or measure where to go or what to do next.



So, when reforming, recuperating, and reawakening parts of our embodiment and correcting mind-body patterns, especially as we age, instead of referring so much to our personal narratives, in Katonah Yoga, measure is used.

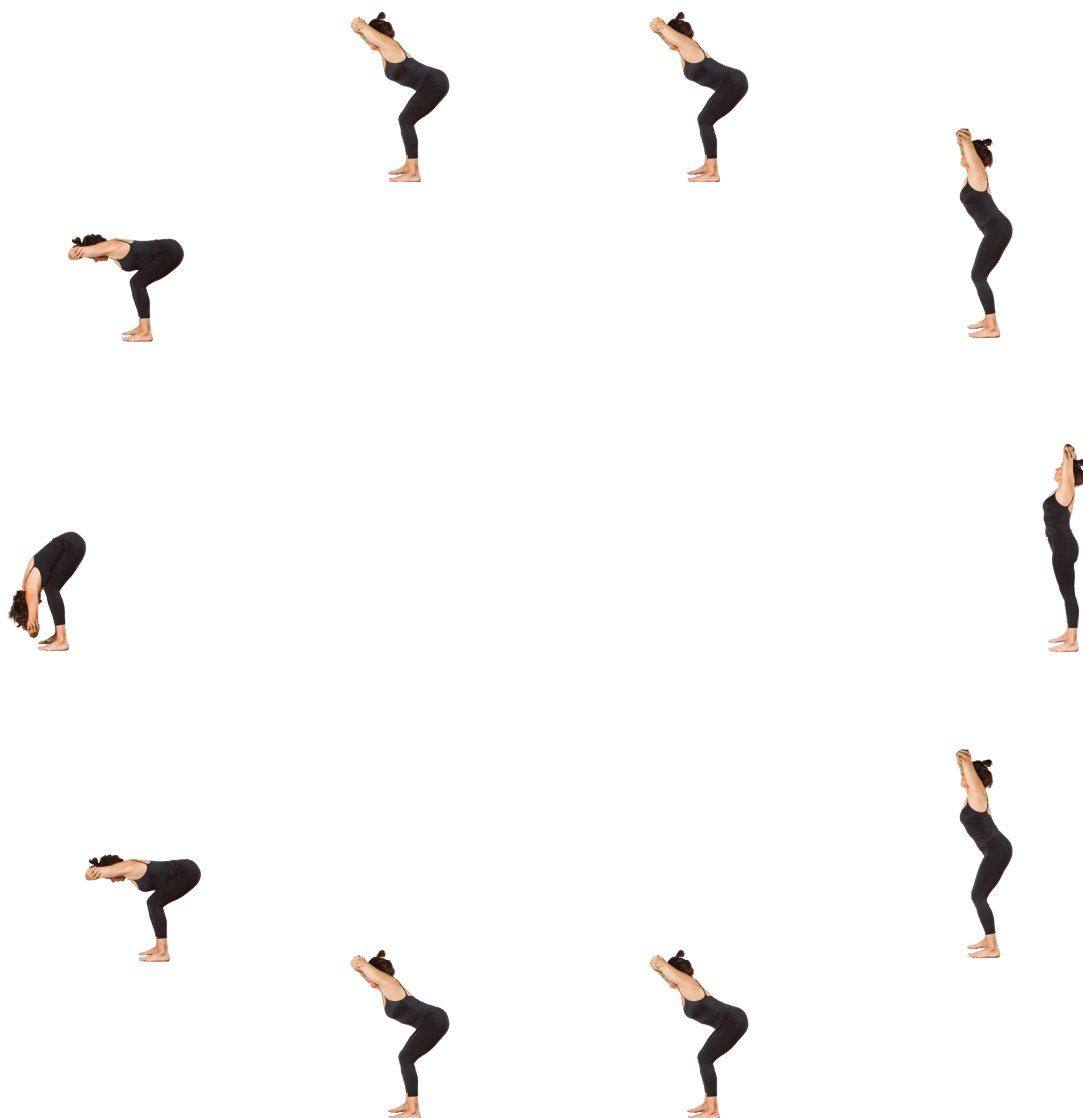
The Geometry of Embodiment

Geometry gives us a way to measure and reorganize our body. Circles, triangles, and squares are archetypes that help us find structure and direction in our own embodiment. When we work with geometric measure, we reawaken the body's memory of coherence and function. These universal energetic principles remind our tissues, joints, and breath how to move in right relationship with gravity, with space, and with nature.

Imagine being in the center of a joint. Through the subtle navigation of proprioception—our internal compass—the body begins to organize around that center. When we inhabit the center of joint space, gravity becomes a nutrient for our bones rather than a source of wear and tear. Otherwise, a single degree of misalignment, magnified through repetition, can accumulate over time. Small deviations in structure can become amplified through compensation, resulting in patterns of tension and long-term imbalance.

The body experiences misalignment exponentially: the longer a pattern persists, the longer it takes to recover or correct. To measure is to make formal; to make formal is to refine. Through practice and precision, we become formidable.

Using measure helps us find the center of a joint, and the body only articulates upward from that center. This is how we build our bones. When the skeleton is well-stacked and supported, gravity participates in osteogenesis—the natural process of bone growth. Just as weight-bear



Hangs take us into the first floor of the body, into the basement where experiences and ideas compost. We go deep not to stay there, but to learn how to rise again—to meet the moment and reach for the stars.

Endnotes

1 I found the phrase, presence of absence, when I was doing the somatic grief work in *The Dying We Do* classes. In my mind, I had it lumped together with Drew Leder's work, but I think I must have gotten it somewhere else

2 Leder, D. (1990). *The absent body*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.

3 This aspect of the body disappearing as a good thing is worth exploring deeper. In the many conversations with my dissertation chair Dr. Cliff Smyth, we often talked about the experience-of-the-body-as-physical and how most people think of the body only symbolically. These conversations often generated many reading lists in his mind. One was the work of Kristin Zeiler, who wrote the paper using Leder's idea on the dys-appearance of the body in pain and illness, and positing eu-appearance as an additional construct. Eu-appearance (using the root of eu meaning good or well) suggests that the lack of awareness of our body is ideal. It means that we can be absorbed in whatever it is we are doing. We can be in a being state. Abbie Galvin often says that you know when you are in the center of the joint in a form when you don't feel anything. So there is a lot of feeling and sensing needed to get to the point of not having to feel and sense, and instead, just be. The Zeiler paper is: Zeiler, K. (2010). A phenomenological analysis of bodily self-awareness in the experience of pain and pleasure: on dys-appearance and eu-appearance, *Medicine Health Care and Philosophy*, (13), 4, 333-342 <http://dx.doi.org/10.1007/s11019-010-9237-4>

4 Fuchs, T. (2010). Phenomenology and psychopathology. In D. Schmicking & S. Gallagher (Eds.), *Handbook of phenomenology and cognitive science* (pp. 194–200). Springer Science & Business Media. <https://www.proquest.com/docview/1936210851?accountid=34120&source-type=Scholarly%20Journals>